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Connecting China, Latin America, and the Caribbean: infrastructure and everyday life

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BOOK REVIEW

Connecting China, Latin America, and the Caribbean: infrastructure and everyday life, edited by Enrique Dussel Peters, James A. Cook, & Joseph S. Alter, University of Pittsburgh Press, 2024, 312 pp., US$60.00 (hardback)

For nearly two decades, scholarship on China's engagement with Latin America was preoccupied with the 'China Boom', a period defined by rising commodity prices, vast shipments of soy and copper, and state-to-state lending. *Connecting China, Latin America, and the Caribbean: Infrastructure and Everyday Life* offers a necessary corrective to this high-altitude view. Moving beyond the institutional political-economy focus of recent works such as Carol Wise's *Dragonomics* (2020), which maps the institutional variations that determine trade outcomes, this volume argues that the relationship has entered a 'qualitative' phase (3). It highlights that the reality of Sino-Latin American integration is not found solely in GDP statistics, but in the friction of physical infrastructure and the texture of daily social life.

The volume is thematically organised into sections on 'Chinese Immigration' and 'Chinese Infrastructure Projects', demonstrating how abstract geopolitical strategies crash into local realities. Where Wise (2020) might analyse the state-level policies that allowed Chile to thrive while Brazil hesitated, Dussel Peters et al. examine ground-level realities. They reveal that China's global ambitions are not a monolith imposed from Beijing, but a fragmented reality negotiated by shopkeepers in Santiago and engineers in the Andes.

The section on migration is particularly strong when it discusses the idea of a unified Chinese diaspora. Ariel C. Armony and Rosa Hassan De Ferrari analyse the process of 're-Sinification' (14), the strategic embracing of Chinese identity by descendants, which complicates the narrative of assimilation. Carol Chan's fieldwork in Chile complements this, as she documents deep intra-community divisions between established, often assimilationist Cantonese communities and newer, wealthier Zhejiangnese arrivals, showing a contested hierarchy where class and region of origin determine social standing. There is frequent discussion of the COVID-19 pandemic, with chapters detailing how quickly historic prejudices resurfaced, serving as a reminder that despite strong economic ties, social acceptance remains fragile.

Regarding the discussion on hard infrastructure, the volume provides a dynamic and detailed counterpoint to the security- and strategy-focused narratives often found in recent works such as R. Evan Ellis's *China Engages Latin America* (2022). Ellis (2022) views Chinese engagement primarily through the lens of strategic competition and the use of commercial instruments of state power, while this volume emphasises technical and institutional 'compliance gaps' (123). Diana Castro Salgado's chapter on Ecuador's Coca Codo Sinclair dam is a standout account of this dynamic. Rather than a calculated strategic play, she describes a 'network of mutually enabling special practices' that allowed a project troubled by thousands of structural cracks to proceed (248). This clearly suggests that the failures of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) in this case are often the result of shared institutional weaknesses rather than predatory strategy, as is widely narrated.

The volume also challenges the simple binary of 'state-owned' versus 'private' enterprises. It highlights the 'omnipresence of the public sector' (154), and argues that Chinese firms operate within a unique logic where commercial goals cannot be detached from national strategy. This is clearly illustrated in the chapter on the ECU-911 integrated security system.

As a form of digital governance infrastructure, this project exports not just hardware but a specific model of public security. While the author highlights its efficiency in reducing response times, the deployment of such technology simultaneously introduces complexities regarding data privacy and surveillance that standard economic analyses of infrastructure often overlook.

Yet, the book is not simply a catalogue of failures. It identifies a shift towards complex technological transfer. Madhavan and Rawski's analysis of State Grid in Brazil shows China exporting cutting-edge Ultra High Voltage (UHV) technology, suggesting that China is no longer just paving roads but rewriting the region's technical standards.

Connecting China, Latin America, and the Caribbean compels the reader to look beyond capital cities and trade summits. It provides the essential, granular evidence needed to understand how the global ambitions of a superpower are constructed and contested on the ground.

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